

## **Assignment 2: Developmental Context Analysis Report**

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### **Background**

Cyberbullying presents a major problem for young people in Aotearoa New Zealand. In a Netsafe and Ministry for Women study, 70% of New Zealand adolescents had experienced at least one type of unwanted digital communication, and 19% reported an electronic message that disrupted their daily activities (Pacheco & Melhuish, 2018). A further Netsafe study found that 25% of 2,061 nine to seventeen-year-olds had been distressed online within the last year, with 12–17 year olds most at risk (Pacheco, 2020). Cyberbullying is therefore common among young New Zealanders.

The effects on victims are well documented. Nixon (2014) reports that 93% of cybervictims experienced adverse effects, most commonly sadness, hopelessness and powerlessness, and that victimisation correlates with anxiety, depression, loneliness and suicidal ideation. Dennehy et al. (2020) link cybervictimisation with sleep problems, school avoidance and absence, low self-esteem, and somatic symptoms such as headache and poor appetite. In New Zealand, the most frequently reported effects were being upset, annoyed and unable to engage in normal daily activities (Pacheco & Melhuish, 2018).

Parents and schools are both central to intervention. Tozzo et al. (2022) found that parental regulation and monitoring of online activity, teacher training, and whole-school strategies such as digital literacy teaching and anti-bullying measures reduce cyberbullying. Hendry et al. (2023) highlight parental involvement in technology use and open discussion of online experiences, while Helfrich et al. (2020) identify parental communication, monitoring and social support as successful coping strategies. In New Zealand, Netsafe offers guidance and a reporting process under the Harmful Digital Communications Act 2015, providing a formal course of action for those harmed.

### **Developmental Context**

#### **Bronfenbrenner's Ecological Systems Theory**

Urie Bronfenbrenner (1917–2005) developed ecological systems theory, which holds that development reflects the influence of five nested environmental systems: the microsystem, mesosystem, exosystem, macrosystem and chronosystem (Santrock, 2024, p. 26). Individuals are not passive recipients of experience but actively help to construct their settings (Santrock, 2024, p. 27). The theory is widely used to analyse how contexts beyond

the family shape development (Santrock, 2024, p. 28), and it frames the analysis of Carrie's story that follows.

The microsystem is the immediate environment in which the person exists (e.g., home, school, neighborhood, peer group) and where the most face-to-face interactions with social agents occur (Santrock, 2024, p. 27). For Carrie, two specific microsystem environments are especially pertinent. Firstly, her family microsystem has experienced major upheaval. Her father's frequent places of work have caused her to change schools many times, and her mother's new florist business has meant she works long hours and Carrie coming home to an empty house and spending less time with her parents. Her bond with her elder brother Giles has also grown cold, and she has consequently lost family support. Additionally, her school and peer microsystem at Girl's High is quite demanding. Having just transferred to an all-girls school where the social cliques have long been in place, Carrie finds it hard to know the social code of being in the in group and being accepted. Joining the swim team is a new peer setting, but her growing body and physical self-consciousness are now the target for a new form of social media-based bullying.

Relationships or interactions between microsystems, or links between contexts, constitute the mesosystem, e.g., the connection between home and school experiences (Santrock, 2024, p. 27). For Carrie, the link between her family and the school microsystem is particularly fragile. Her working parents are too busy with work to really be there for her school life and the fact that Jane's father works for Carrie's father complicates the situation and stops Carrie from talking to her parents about the bullying. The family microsystem, usually a buffer against school-related problems, was unable to do so, as work was the main focus for the parents and Carrie was unwilling to trouble her exhausted mother. The lack of mesosystem support isolates Carrie from the connecting function that the mesosystem usually performs.

The exosystem is made up of connections from a social environment in which the individual is not an active participant to their own immediate environment (Santrock, 2024, p. 27). Carrie is not employed by her father, but his appointment and change of residence to the Head Office was the reason for the family's most recent move, which required her to change schools and social connections in Christchurch. Like her brother, Carrie is not part of her mother's florist business, but her mother's choice to go into this business has greatly diminished the amount of parental oversight and emotional support Carrie has at home. Another systemic factor is the legislative context: the Harmful Digital Communications Act 2015 and Netsafe, a reporting authority (Pacheco & Melhuish, 2018), are systems into which Carrie herself does not enter but which serve as the structures within which her school guidance counsellor can react.

The macrosystem is that culture in which the individual exists and involves the customs, beliefs and other products of a culture that are handed down through the ages (Santrock,

2024, p. 27). Multiple macro-cultural influences affect Carrie's experience. As New Zealand's digital society grows, social media adoption among youth is becoming the norm and social media sites such as Instagram, TikTok and Snapchat are the main social venues and thus the main sites of social victimisation. Societal standards of female beauty, including the imposition of standards of bodily perfection and leg hair, make Carrie susceptible to body-directed teasing. Furthermore, gendered social expectations that tend to be less harsh about online than face-to-face bullying and that fail to acknowledge the online aspects tend to influence how the school first responds, as indicated by the school's cyberbullying policy that is still being developed.

### **Baltes' Lifespan Perspective**

Baltes's life-span perspective views development as lifelong, multidimensional, multidirectional, plastic and multidisciplinary, and as involving growth, maintenance and regulation of loss (Santrock, 2024, p. 4). Development is also contextual, occurring within historical, economic, social and cultural conditions that exert three types of influence: normative age-graded influences, normative history-graded influences and nonnormative life events (Santrock, 2024, p. 5).

Normative age-graded influences are biological and environmental changes common to a particular age group, such as puberty (Santrock, 2024, p. 5). Carrie's puberty, with its increased height, breast development and body hair, is an age-graded influence that directly increased her vulnerability, as these changes became the target of the Instagram page voting for 'Hairiest Legs'. Normative history-graded influences are influences associated with history that a generation shares (Santrock, 2024, p. 6). Carrie's cohort is the first to experience social media as a core setting of adolescence, making cyberbullying via Instagram and Snapchat a time-specific influence that past generations did not encounter. Nonnormative life events are unusual occurrences with a major impact on the individual that do not happen to all people (Santrock, 2024, p. 6). Carrie's family's frequent moves between London, Brussels and Christchurch are nonnormative events that disrupted her friendships and social development.

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